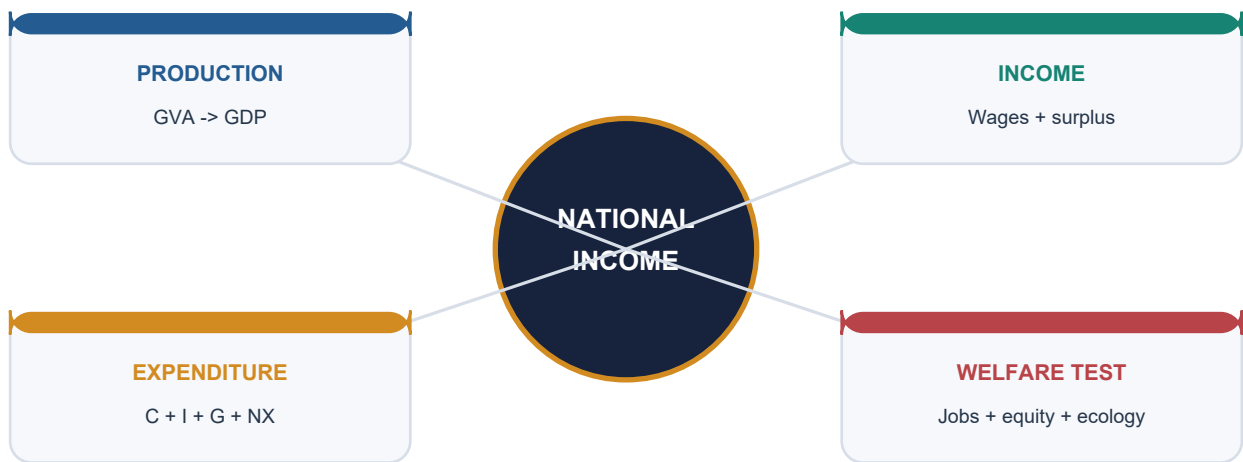


Polity 03 - Salient Features: Complete Topic Package

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Deterministic fallback visual: national income viewed through production, income, expenditure and welfare lenses.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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PART II - Solved locally routed PYQs

Verified Mains PYQs

2019 GS-II Q1 - Explain whether the Constitution accepts strict separation of powers rather than checks and balances. (10 marks, 150 words)

[FACT] India rejects strict organ isolation and adopts functional separation with checks and balances. Ram Jawaya Kapur (1955) recognised that the constitutional scheme does not contemplate rigid separation, although core functions are differentiated.

[FACT] The text creates insulation: Article 50 directs separation of the judiciary from the executive; Articles 121 and 211 protect judges from ordinary legislative discussion of conduct; Articles 122 and 212 protect legislative procedure; Article 361 provides specified immunity to the President and Governors. Yet overlap is deliberate. The executive participates in legislation and may promulgate ordinances under Articles 123 and 213; the Council of Ministers is collectively responsible to the lower House under Article 75; courts review laws through Articles 13, 32 and 226.

[ANALYSIS] These arrangements permit coordinated government while preventing one organ from becoming final in its own cause. Kesavananda Bharati (1973) and Indira Nehru Gandhi (1975) protect separation and review within basic-structure doctrine.

[LIMIT] Overlap is valid only while each organ respects constitutional competence and institutional restraint. Thus India balances power rather than separating it absolutely.

Why this earns marks: direct thesis; named Articles and cases; mechanism; qualification; directive answered.

2021 GS-II Q1 - Explain the doctrine of constitutional morality and its essential facets with illustrations. (10 marks, 150 words)

[ANALYSIS] Constitutional morality is disciplined fidelity to constitutional forms, methods and values over personal, partisan or majoritarian preference. Ambedkar used the expression, drawing on George Grote, to stress that democratic institutions require habits of restraint.

[FACT] Its facets include rule of law; reasoned exercise of power; respect for procedure and institutional roles; protection of liberty, equality, dignity and pluralism; accountability of constitutional functionaries; and minority protection. The Preamble and Articles 14, 15, 19, 21 and 25 provide textual anchors.

[FACT] Navtej Singh Johar (2018) preferred constitutional values to exclusionary social morality; the Sabarimala judgments (2018) used equality, dignity and religious-freedom reasoning; Government of NCT of Delhi v. Union of India (2018) connected constitutional morality with representative government and federal balance.

[LIMIT] The doctrine can become subjective if detached from text and structure. It should discipline institutions, not authorise a judge's personal morality.

[ANALYSIS] Constitutional morality therefore converts written forms into a culture of justified, restrained and inclusive public power.

Why this earns marks: definition, essential facets, three illustrations, textual evidence and a clear limiting caution.

Locally routed Prelims PYQs and ownership-aware solutions

[LIMIT] Exact wording is reproduced only where the local official paper was directly extractable. Demand-only ledger entries are not reverse-engineered into invented options. When the official key is unavailable, the answer is prominently labelled inferred.

2018 Q40 routed demand: relationship between law and liberty

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: law is a condition of ordered liberty when general and constitutional law restrains arbitrary power. Confidence: high.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

2018 Q45 routed demand: main features of rule of law

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: supremacy of regular law, equality before law and legal protection against arbitrariness are core. Confidence: high.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

2020 Q7 exact locally extracted: A constitutional government by definition is (a) government by legislature (b) popular government (c) multi-party government (d) limited government

Answer: D, limited government. The defining idea is enforceable limitation of public power, not merely popularity or institutional form. Official key not held locally for this paper; confidence: high.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

2021 Q87 routed demand: definition of State in political theory

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: population, territory, government and sovereignty form the conventional four-element definition. Confidence: high.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

2021 Q90 routed demand: best safeguard of liberty in liberal democracy

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: an independent judiciary and rule of law are the strongest institutional safeguard among conventional options. Confidence depends on exact options.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

2021 Q94 routed demand: constitutional government and limiting authority

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: constitutional government is limited government whose authority is defined and restrained. Confidence: high.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

2023 Q33 exact locally extracted: Which statement best reflects the chief purpose of a Constitution? (a) determines objectives for necessary laws (b) enables political offices and government (c) defines and limits powers of government (d) secures social justice, equality and security

Answer: C. A Constitution both constitutes and limits public power; the other options describe possible purposes but not the chief defining function. Official key unavailable locally; confidence: high.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

2023 Q84 exact locally extracted: Flag Code statement I says 600 mm x 400 mm is a standard size; statement II says length:width is 3:2

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: both statements are correct and statement II explains statement I, because 600:400 equals 3:2. Confidence: high; this is a cross-owned national-symbol detail.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

2024 Q74 exact official Set A: Part IX-A Municipalities; Part XVIII Emergencies; Part XX Amendment - which are correct?

OFFICIALLY VERIFIED SET-A ANSWER: D, 1, 2 and 3. All three Part mappings are correct. This is directly owned by Salient Features and cross-owned by Local Government, Emergency and Amendment topics.

Why this earns marks: it states answer-key status, gives the constitutional distinction and preserves ownership limits.

PART III - Learning MCQ loops

Use these as six four-question loops. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D without consecutive repetition.

MCQ 1. Which statement best distinguishes a feature from a provision?

- A. A feature is a system-level characteristic produced by multiple rules
- B. A feature is always a single Article
- C. A provision is always an institution
- D. A value and a feature are identical

Answer: A. Federalism is a feature emerging from many provisions and institutions.

MCQ 2. Why is the Constitution unusually detailed?

- A. Only because it was written by lawyers
- B. Diversity, 1935 Act influence, Union-State coverage and administrative detail
- C. Because every convention was prohibited
- D. Only because it contains Fundamental Rights

Answer: B. The verified four-factor account makes B the best answer.

MCQ 3. Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Concurrent List - Canada
- B. DPSP - United States
- C. Procedure established by law - Japan
- D. Fundamental Duties - Ireland

Answer: C. Japan is the conventional source for the phrase; the distractors swap sources.

MCQ 4. Which amendment route is not a universal requirement?

- A. Special majority
- B. Simple majority for specified matters
- C. State ratification for specified federal matters
- D. Referendum for every Article 368 amendment

Answer: D. India has no universal constitutional referendum requirement.

MCQ 5. Which formulation is most accurate?

- A. India is a federation with centralising features
- B. India is purely unitary
- C. States created the Union by compact
- D. States possess a right to secede

Answer: A. The first preserves both federal structure and Union strength.

MCQ 6. Collective responsibility primarily links the Council of Ministers to which body?

- A. Rajya Sabha
- B. Lok Sabha at Union level
- C. Supreme Court
- D. Election Commission

Answer: B. Article 75 responsibility is to the House of the People.

MCQ 7. Which case supports the proposition that India lacks rigid separation?

- A. Minerva Mills
- B. Kesavananda only
- C. Ram Jawaya Kapur
- D. S.R. Bommai only

Answer: C. Ram Jawaya is the direct proposition.

MCQ 8. Which claim is incorrect?

- A. Parliament has broad constituent power
- B. Courts exercise judicial review
- C. The Constitution is supreme
- D. Indian Parliament is sovereign in the British sense

Answer: D. Written limits and review reject British-style parliamentary sovereignty.

MCQ 9. DPSP are best described as

- A. non-justiciable but fundamental in governance
- B. judicially enforceable exactly like Fundamental Rights
- C. ordinary political promises outside the Constitution
- D. penal duties of citizens

Answer: A. Article 37 supplies the exact distinction.

MCQ 10. The word 'secular' was inserted in the Preamble by

- A. 44th Amendment
- B. 42nd Amendment
- C. 61st Amendment
- D. 73rd Amendment

Answer: B. The 42nd Amendment, 1976 inserted secular, socialist and integrity.

MCQ 11. Universal adult franchise chiefly constitutionalised

- A. administrative centralisation
- B. judicial appointment
- C. equal political membership
- D. dual citizenship

Answer: C. It made adult citizens politically equal without literacy/property qualification.

MCQ 12. Which is not an integrating constitutional device?

- A. Single citizenship
- B. Integrated judiciary
- C. All-India Services
- D. Dual State citizenship

Answer: D. India does not adopt dual State citizenship.

PART IV - Solved original Mains practice

Original 10-marker - Why is India described as federal with a unitary bias?

[FACT] India distributes authority constitutionally between Union and States, yet equips the Union with stronger coordinating and crisis powers.

[FACT] Federal evidence includes dual governments, legislative lists, written supremacy, bicameralism and an independent judicial umpire. Article 1's 'Union of States', Union residuary power, appointed Governors, single citizenship, integrated courts, All-India Services and emergency provisions create centralising capacity.

[ANALYSIS] The mechanism is variable geometry: normal governance is federal; cooperative institutions support joint action; asymmetry accommodates diversity; emergencies temporarily shift the balance.

[LIMIT] Strength of the Centre does not erase State constitutional status. Nor does federal form prevent central overreach in practice.

[ANALYSIS] The best verdict is therefore a federation with centralising features, not a purely federal or unitary State.

Why this earns marks: balanced classification, named constitutional evidence, operational explanation and a qualified verdict.

Original 15-marker - The Indian Constitution is borrowed yet original. Discuss.

[FACT] The Constitution's components have identifiable sources, but constitutional originality lies in selection, alteration and combination for Indian conditions.

[FACT] From Britain came cabinet government, rule of law and single citizenship, but India rejected hereditary monarchy and parliamentary sovereignty. From the United States came rights, review and judicial independence, but not presidential government, dual citizenship or rigid separation. Canada influenced a strong-Centre federation; Ireland influenced Directive Principles; Australia the Concurrent List and joint sitting; the 1935 Act supplied administrative structure.

[ANALYSIS] Adaptation created combinations not reducible to any source: parliamentary federalism; enforceable rights plus non-justiciable social directives; universal franchise from commencement; single citizenship within a dual polity; constitutional asymmetry; emergency centralisation within a written order.

[FACT] Administrative continuity from 1935 was transformed by popular sovereignty, republican government, rights and judicial remedies.

[LIMIT] Borrowing did carry centralising and legalistic legacies, and detailed transplantation does not ensure suitable practice.

[ANALYSIS] Therefore the 'bag of borrowings' criticism confuses the ancestry of parts with the identity of the whole.

Why this earns marks: comparative evidence is used analytically, rejected models demonstrate choice, and the conclusion directly answers originality.

Original 20-marker - Evaluate the strengths and tensions within the salient features of the Indian Constitution.

[ANALYSIS] The Constitution is a designed balance between governing capacity, liberty, diversity and transformation. Its strength is the interaction of features; its tensions arise when one side overwhelms another.

[FACT] First, federal distribution accommodates territory, while Article 1, Union residuary authority, All-India Services and emergency powers create national capacity. This aids coordination but can produce centralisation. Second, parliamentary responsibility allows removal of the executive through the lower House; disciplined majorities can nevertheless convert responsibility into executive dominance.

[FACT] Third, written supremacy, Articles 13, 32 and 226, and an independent integrated judiciary protect limited government. Review secures rights and federal boundaries, but debates over judicial overreach and democratic legitimacy require reasoned restraint. Fourth, Parts III, IV and IV-A join liberty, welfare and civic responsibility. Minerva Mills supports harmony, yet rights restrictions and social reform remain contested.

[FACT] Fifth, universal franchise, republican government and independent election administration support political equality; unequal social capacity can still limit substantive participation. Sixth, asymmetry, language safeguards and affirmative action accommodate diversity, while demands for uniformity create political tension. Seventh, detail creates clarity but also complexity; graded amendment supports adaptation but basic structure preserves identity.

[FACT] The 1935 Act supplied machinery, but popular sovereignty, rights and universal franchise transformed its purpose.

[LIMIT] None of these balances is self-executing. Parties, conventions, administrative capacity, public reason and constitutional morality shape outcomes.

[ANALYSIS] The Constitution is strongest when central capacity remains federal, majority rule remains rights-bound, and transformative action remains accountable.

Why this earns marks: covers multiple dimensions with named evidence, explains each trade-off, includes limitations and gives a graded evaluative conclusion.